decisively in China's favour economically – this is well known, though the huge size of the gap is worth underlining. In military terms, China holds a lead, but after accounting for geography and possible Indian strategic responses the gap appears quite modest. This flies in the face of a general perception that the Chinese military will be rampant in a conflict. As for soft power, contrary to the generally held view, China betters India. The economic, military, and cultural elements of power are synergistic: they each magnify the other, so unfortunately for India, the power gap becomes even more formidable. If you have more economic and military power, there is a good chance that others will be 'persuaded' to do what you want. If you have cultural or soft power, you can conserve the use of hard power for when you really need it and not fritter it away over every disagreement.

In 1998, I was in Singapore for an international conference on the newly formed ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF). The main ARF countries were all represented – the ten countries of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) and the ten ASEAN Dialogue Partners. The Dialogue Partners included Australia, China, the European Union, India, Japan, and the US. My memory is that the biggest delegations were from China and the US and that their teams were of equal strength. Today, this would not surprise – it would be a considerable diplomatic error if either had more delegates than the other. In 1998, the China–US parity made you think. At the same time, the India–China gap was quite apparent: I think there were only two of us representing India.

It was a stimulating conference for what was said but just as interesting for what was not said – the seemingly innocuous performances and actions which in fact turned out to be rather significant. For one thing, the Chinese delegates were unlike any academics and officials from the mainland that I had previously encountered. The men and women delegates were young, dressed in tight black business suits, and all over the floor during the breaks, busily engaging delegates from the other countries. They looked